W5H

**Network Neutrality**

**What is Network Neutrality?**
Network Neutrality is a policy that aims to equalise the Internet, basically stating that network providers should treat all Web sites equally and serve them to users the best they can. The aim is to enable users to choose sites based on content rather than how fast they receive them from servers.

**Who is fighting for it?**
In his paper *Network Neutrality, Broadband Discrimination*, Columbia University Professor Tim Wu talks about the eerie idea that network operators could decide which sites open faster for you based on how much they pay the operators. There is also the "Save the Internet" Coalition that aims to unite the world in an effort to protect Network Neutrality.

**Why are they fighting?**
The US Congress seems all set to pass a law that will send Network Neutrality packing. Operators will then be able to sell their best services to the highest bidder—pay more, and your site will open faster. Web hosts will become like your local *cablewallah*—deciding what you should see based on what's profitable.

**How does it affect me?**
Imagine a situation where your competitor pays a network provider like Sify to optimise performance for their site, and not for yours. Corporate sabotage will go through the roof, and you, the user, will suffer the worst. Your very freedom to surf whatever you want will be threatened: eventually you'll end up patronising the sites your operator wants you to.

**When did this madness start?**
On June 8, 2006, the US House of Representatives passed the "Communications Opportunity, Promotion and Enhancement Act of 2006" (COPE)—an act that has no protection for Network Neutrality.

**Where can I find more info?**
To read Tim Wu's paper, visit **http://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=388863** To find out more about the Save the Internet Coalition, visit **www.savetheinternet.com.**

MADE IN INDIA

# IIT IDC DDS?

The Industrial Design Center (IDC) at IIT Bombay showcased the design talents of their graduating batch at the Design Degree Show (DDS) 2006 on June 10 and 11.

Technology was clearly a key point at the show, with students' designs going from the wild and improbable to ideas that we might end up seeing in our daily lives before we know it. Among such intriguing works was Susheel Kewalay's interactive device for traffic policemen, allowing them to effectively "wear" traffic signals on their hands—no more frantic waving!

We were also drawn by Abhishek Chitranshi's mobile phone for the elderly—complete with big buttons and an emergency button should ol' gramps need some immediate assistance finding his dentures (or just want to annoy you). Of course, the idea isn't new—a similar idea debuted at CeBIT this year, but Abhishek points out the brilliance of the phone's camera: since the elderly have trouble holding their hands up for very long, which results in shaky photos, the camera is designed at an angle, so one can take a photo without raising one's arm much.


#1 DAYTIME MEDIUM

# Web High Up In Media Rankings

Now, in a first-of-its-kind study, it has been found that the Web is the predominant information medium in the workplace, is the #1 daytime medium, and is #2 in the home. This was documented in a report from the Online Publishers Association (OPA).

Further, the study says 17 per cent of *all* media is consumed via the Web. This is a conservative estimate, and other researchers have placed the 17 per cent figure even higher.

These figures were reached via a research project by Ball State University's Center for Media Design. It tracked, every 15 seconds, how 350 people in the US used the media. The genders were represented about equally, and each person was monitored by another person for 80 per cent of the waking day.

"Someone actually came into their homes and workplaces and had a handheld computer, every 15 seconds registering their media consumption and life activities," Pam Horan, president of the OPA, told CNET News.com. This is a first-of-its-kind study because in all earlier studies of this sort, people were simply questioned about media usage via phone surveys and such.

The study used census data to determine the spending habits of the 350 monitored subjects. Web-dominant consumers' annual retail spending averaged $26,450 (Rs 12 lakh), while TV-dominant consumers' spending averaged considerably lower, at $21,401 (Rs 9.8 lakh). Despite this, only about 8 per cent of all advertising is done on the Web, according to other studies.

"I hear more and more from marketers that they have shifted their business to be more responsive and realign. There is an active movement by traditional advertisers to be able to explore platform strategies," said Horan, who believes research studies are attracting the attention of advertisers, and may result in a faster shift in ad spending to match the actual statistics of consumer media usage.

Interestingly, the researchers conducting the OPA study found a direct correlation between Web traffic and offline referrals to Web sites. For example, when PBS—the US public broadcasting network—told people they could find more information on PBS.org about the topic being discussed, people do go to that Web site; the same was found for print referrals to publications such as The New York Times (NYTimes.com).

Most of this comes as no surprise: Internet penetration is ever-increasing, and the growth and popularity of broadband is driving more people to the Web. However, it remains to be seen whether advertising on the Web can be made more effective, since it is so easy to click away from ads on the Net. Perhaps we'll soon be seeing more intrusive methods of online advertising, such as having to view an ad before moving on to a news article.

The 17 per cent figure—which we can conceivably augment to 20 or 25 per cent, since that's a conservative estimate—is significant. The finding also corroborates with the fact that in countries with high Internet penetration, print is going out of fashion. Online ad spending can only increase, partly because as this and other studies have found, Web surfers are richer and spend more on the average. ■